

Is this the future we dreaming of?

This Was Tomorrow: Is This the Future We Were Dreaming Of? is a long-term audio-visual investigation by artist and photographer Enrico Policardo into community-led housing across the UK - cohousing, Community Land Trusts, cooperative living, retrofit and repair.

It looks at places that are functioning in the present, without framing them as models or solutions. The question throughout is not "does this work?" but something closer to: what futures are still imaginable from where we are now?

The work began in 2022, with the fundamental input of architectural historian Judith Martin, documenting endangered council estates in London and the utopian ideals held in their concrete. A residency at ESAD IDEA in Porto, made possible by David Marques (Devity Studio), shifted the focus - from documenting past utopias to watching the present, and asking why we seem to have lost the postwar momentum that once drove us to build, to house, to look at the future with pragmatism and hope.

This phase turns to what people are doing now, from the bottom up - not waiting for the institutions once meant to enable and protect them, but acting for themselves. The aim was never to document these places from the outside, but to distil, in images and voices, what moved such different people into action - and to carry some of their energy and their dreams to you.

Places and voices

Beside each photograph, an A4 sheet tells you about the place, with a QR code to hear the people who live there. Please use headphones while you listen - the work is made to be taken at your own pace, and to keep the places and the people around you undisturbed.

A second QR code opens the quote generator: lines drawn at random from all the interviews, a further layer if you want one. Scan, listen, read, in any order.

Acknowledgments

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This Was Tomorrow grew out of an earlier iteration and two editions of a book of the same title. For more info please visit thiswastomorrow.co.uk or enricopolicardo.com



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About the author

Enrico Policardo

Photographer and artist based in London. His work examines how systems of power organise everyday life and who gets to shape it - the consumer economy, identity and borders, and the ways people make community and what community even means.

Creative Director of ReThinkable Festival on the Italy-Slovenia border (Nova Gorica / Gorizia, European Capital of Culture 2024-2026) and an Affiliate Research Fellow at the University of Nova Gorica.

enricopolicardo.com

Quote Generator

Scan the QR code
for the quote
generator; a webpage
that pulls a random
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This Was Tomorrow, supported by Arts Council England, documents communities across the UK who have taken housing into their own hands.

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